GOVERNMENT OF SPANISH CALIFORNIA

PROVINCIA DE CALIFORNIAS · PROVINCE OF THE CALIFORNIAS · one province 1769–1804, then NUEVA (ALTA) CALIFORNIA to 1821 · a civil-military command

THE CROWN
King of Spain (Carlos III, then Carlos IV) · Madrid
owns the empire; rules California by written decree (real cédula)

law & appeals

Council of the Indies
(Consejo de Indias · Madrid)
top court & law-writer for the colonies

Minister of the Indies
(Secretaría de Indias — José de Gálvez, 1776–87)
ran day-to-day colonial government for the king

Viceroy of New Spain
(Virrey · Mexico City) — the king's stand-in in the Americas
appointed, paid & supplied California's governor

1776–1793

Commandant General, Provincias Internas
a frontier military super-command for the far north
(created 1776, Croix, at Arizpe). Held CA 1776–93, from 1788
in its western half (Ugarte, C-A 4 d373); detached 1793 → Viceroy

after 1793:
direct to Viceroy

governor's office

Secretary of Government
(secretario) — writes & sends the governor's orders

Asesor (legal advisor)
gave legal rulings — but CA seldom had one

Habilitado (paymaster)
held the purse: presidio pay, supply & accounts

GOVERNOR of the Californias
gobernador político y militar — runs EVERYTHING in CA:
troops, land grants, courts, Indians, trade & the missions
seat: Loreto → Monterey (Real Orden 19 Apr 1776, eff. 1777 — C-A 1 d85)

appoints comisionado

military command

escort + vice-patrón

Patronato Real
the Crown controls the Church in the Indies;
the governor acts locally as its vice-patrón

Bishop of Sonora
California's diocese before 1840 (secular clergy)
the bishop over the pueblos' parish churches
its seat sat far off in Sonora, on the mainland

the bishop did NOT run the missions —
the friars were a separate, exempt religious order

Apostolic College of San Fernando
the Franciscan order's HQ in Mexico City
trains & sends the friars (exempt from the bishop)

Father-Presidente
(Serra, then Lasuén) — the friars' own local head
directs the whole mission chain

spiritual line

PUEBLOS (civil towns)
settler farm-towns: San José 1777, Los Ángeles 1781,
Branciforte 1797 (the 1778 pueblo plan — C-A 1 d127)
run by a Comisionado (governor's agent) +
an elected Alcalde & Regidores (town council)

PRESIDIOS (royal forts)
the army & police of CA: Loreto (Baja, 1697) + San Diego,
Santa Bárbara, Monterey, San Francisco — the 5 presidios (C-A 2 d330)
each under a Comandante; a Habilitado pays them;
they garrison the mission guards (escoltas)

campaigns / capture

MISSIONS (Franciscan)
21 farm-churches (1769–1823) built to convert
& put Indians to work (Baja's = DOMINICAN, see 1804 chart)
friars answer to their College (spiritual) AND
the governor (escort & secular) = dual control

Indian mission officials
alcaldes & regidores — elected neophytes who
policed labor & discipline (established 1779–83)
+ mayordomos — estate overseers

Gente de razón
"people of reason" = the settler colonists
(vecinos) & the presidio soldiers

Independent Indians (gentiles)
unbaptized Indians beyond the missions —
the presidios campaign to control them

Mission Indians (neófitos)
baptized Indians —
the missions' labor force

▶ THE 1804 SPLIT

Las Californias is divided in two: ALTA (governor now at Monterey) and BAJA (governor at Loreto). Ordered by the King 1804, EFFECTED 1806 — Goycoechea recognized at Loreto 5 Jul 1806; the line = the arroyo del Rosario, following the 1772 Franciscan–Dominican mission boundary (C-A 25). ▶ See the companion chart THE TWO CALIFORNIAS · 1804.

HOW TO READ THIS CHART

- solid arrow = chain of command (appoints / issues orders / answers to)
- dashed arrow = intermittent / changing authority (the Provincias Internas)
- dotted arrow = a church line of authority
- = the governor (the focus of this chart)
- = a superior office whose power over California came and went
- = Church institutions (the bishop's diocese AND the separate Franciscan order)

The dashed line marks the split: the friars answered to their order, not the bishop. Indian officials + bishop sourced from the C-A catalog (ca23, ca25, ca34).

Source: Aodhan Coyne, research file "governor-of-california-office-profile" · Bancroft, History of California I–III. Compiled 2026-08-04 · updated 2026-10-16 (Loreto added to the presidio line; Provincias Internas dates per C-A 4 d373; 1804 banner per C-A 25 d570:d587).

THE TWO CALIFORNIAS · 1804

PROVINCIA DE LA NUEVA CALIFORNIA · PROVINCIA DE LA ANTIGUA CALIFORNIA · ordered 1804, effected 1806 · the threads that still tied them together

THE CROWN
King of Spain · wills the division (real orden, 1804)

Viceroy of New Spain
since 1793 BOTH Californias answer straight to him;
one Habilitado General in Mexico City still handles
BOTH provinces' pay & supply (C-A 16 d562)

appoints · pays · supplies

appoints · pays · supplies

ALTA (NUEVA) CALIFORNIA

GOVERNOR of Alta California
José Joaquín de Arrillaga 1804–14 · Pablo Vicente de Solá 1815–21
seat: MONTEREY (Arrillaga worked from San Diego
through the 1806 handover — C-A 25 d587)
keeps: 4 presidios · the Franciscan missions · 3 pueblos

4 PRESIDIOS (Alta)
San Diego · Santa Bárbara · Monterey · San Francisco
San Diego = the southern anchor: its forge, cannon & flour
also served the Dominican frontier (C-A 9 d309, C-A 8 d399)
+ escoltas garrisoning the Franciscan missions

vice-patrón

MISSIONS — FRANCISCAN
Apostolic College of San Fernando (Mexico City) sends the friars;
a Father-Presidente heads the chain, San Diego → San Francisco
the governor follows "the missions of the Colegio" (C-A 25 d587)

PUEBLOS
San José · Los Ángeles · Branciforte
(Baja had no civil pueblos — only the Real de Santa Ana mines)

BAJA (ANTIGUA) CALIFORNIA

GOVERNOR of Baja California
Felipe de Goycoechea 1806–14 · J. D. Argüello 1815–21 (→ de la Toba)
seat: LORETO — sworn in Mexico (Aug 1806, C-A 14 d452),
recognized by the Comandante of Loreto 5 Jul 1806 (C-A 25 d570)
keeps: the Loreto presidio · the Dominican missions · the frontier

PRESIDIO OF LORETO — the only one
the peninsula's single presidio (1697); same revistas, same
inspection & audit machine as the Alta companies (C-A 2–3)
its company detaches the frontier escoltas & the mail escort
capital of Las Californias until 1777; of Baja after 1804

vice-patrón

COMANDANTE DE LA FRONTERA
HQ = Mission San Vicente · a lieutenant (once a mere sergeant)
commands ALL the escoltas of the Dominican frontier missions
as one district (Neve's instrucción, 1781 — C-A 2 d169)
José Manuel Ruiz held it ~1790s–1821; monthly diaries up-chain
"could aid San Diego in danger" (C-A 13 d398)

MISSIONS — DOMINICAN
the Order of Preachers holds the whole peninsula chain,
Loreto north to San Miguel, under its own Padre-Presidente
the governor follows "the missions of the Dominican fathers"

LA LÍNEA DIVISORIA
the Arroyo del Rosario, alias "Barrabás," between San Diego
and Dominican Mission San Miguel — fixed by the padres of both
orders + the Comandante de la Frontera (C-A 25 d587, Dec 1806);
it simply ratifies the 1772 Franciscan–Dominican order
boundary (C-A 62 d19) — the church line became the state line

1 · THE MAIL RELAY
monthly courier: San Diego ↔ frontier ↔ mission-to-mission down the
peninsula ↔ across the Gulf ↔ Álamos / Arizpe → Mexico (C-A 2 d229, C-A 7 d2)

2 · MUTUAL AID & SUPPLY
San Diego arms & provisions the frontier; the frontier company stands
ready to reinforce San Diego (C-A 8 d399, C-A 13 d398)

3 · ONE OFFICER CORPS
careers cross the line: Goycoechea (Santa Bárbara → Gov. of Baja),
Argüello (San Francisco → Gov. of Baja) — and one Habilitado General for both

4 · ONE CHURCH PROVINCE ABOVE THE ORDERS
both halves remain in the Diocese of Sonora; the Crown's patronato
runs through each governor as "vice-patrón" — the king's local
deputy in church patronage (he appoints, funds & protects)

THE CLOSED BACK DOOR — no road east
no overland road to Sonora: prohibited by art. 115 of Gálvez's 1786
instruction (quoted C-A 11 d24); the Yumas held the Colorado crossing
after the 1781 revolt. Reconnaissances only (Arrillaga 1796, C-A 8 d148);
everything heavy for BOTH halves came by sea from San Blas

THE SEA LANE & THE PENINSULAR ROAD
San Blas ships supply both coasts; the goleta shuttles Loreto ↔ San Luis;
travellers & governors ride the mission chain (Borica 1794: Loreto →
Monterey in 4 months, inspecting 10 Dominican + 9 Fernandino houses)
San Vicente sits 250 leguas from Loreto (Arrillaga's 1796 diary)

▶ WHY SPLIT?

A Monterey government "no puede celar á distancia de 600 leguas… hasta el cabo de San Lúcas" — "cannot keep watch at a distance of 600 leagues… to Cape San Lucas" (C-A 54 d216).
And the halves faced different enemies: Alta faced FOREIGN NAVIES — after Nootka, San Francisco was "el último punto que podemos poseer… con completo é independiente dominio,"
"the last point we can hold… in complete and independent dominion" — while Baja faced DISTANCE and the desert frontier.
That is also why Alta got four presidios and Baja kept one: presidios answered ships; escoltas answered the frontier.

HOW TO READ THIS CHART

- solid arrow = chain of command (appoints / issues orders / answers to)
- dotted arrow = a church line of authority
- blue dashed double arrow = a thread ACROSS the division — the ties that kept the halves one system
- = the two governors (equal rank, parallel commands)
- = the dividing line itself (a church boundary promoted to a political one)
- = Church institutions (Franciscan college / Dominican province)

Companion to "Government of Spanish California 1769–1821" and "Government of Mexican California 1822–1846." Every cited record is a BANC MSS C-A document (volume + doc id), readable at archivesofcalifornia.com.
Source: Aodhan Coyne, research file "two-californias-baja-presidios-and-frontier" + leaf read of Arrillaga's 1796 diary (C-A 8 d148). Compiled 2026-10-16.

GOVERNMENT OF MEXICAN CALIFORNIA

TERRITORIO DE LA ALTA CALIFORNIA 1824–36 · DEPARTAMENTO DE CALIFORNIAS 1836–46 · an elected assembly now checks the governor

THE MEXICAN NATION
General Congress + Supreme Executive (the President) · Mexico City
independent 1821; sets national law & names California's governor

Ministry of Relations
(Ministerio de Relaciones, interior & exterior · Mexico City)
the desk that sent orders to California (C-A 34 d539)

appoints & instructs

governor's office

Secretario de Gobierno
secretary/chief of staff — Zamorano, Jimeno, Covarrubias

Asesor (legal advisor)
e.g. Rafael Gómez, 1830s — still only part-time

GOVERNOR of Alta California
Jefe Político Superior (civil) + Comandante General (military)
runs the province, but the two halves were often SPLIT between
two men (Castro / Gutiérrez 1835; Pico / Castro 1845)
seat: Monterey → moved to Los Ángeles by Pico, 1845 (C-A 31 d355)

share power

DIPUTACIÓN TERRITORIAL
installed 1822 at Monterey: the governor presiding,
8 founding vocales + a secretary (the acta, C-A 59 d4)
votes on laws, budgets & land grants; its senior member (primer vocal) takes the government when the seat falls vacant — Castro 1835 (C-A 39 d31), Alvarado 1836 (C-A 45 d55)
▶ the big NEW thing: Spain had no such check

appoints

Prefects & Sub-prefects
(prefecto /subprefecto) — district-level officials
added when the 1836 centralist reform made CA a "departamento";
the district/partido division approved 1839 (C-A 29 d153)

BISHOP OF CALIFORNIA
a resident bishop only from 1840
before that, CA was under the Bishop of Sonora
Diocese of Both Californias · seat San Diego → Sta Bárbara 1842

a SEPARATE church hierarchy — not over the ex-mission friars

oversees towns

commands

state now runs (contested)

CIVIL / LOCAL
Ayuntamientos = elected town councils
(Alcaldes & Regidores) in each pueblo
the Alcalde is also the local judge —
his court = the juzgado (justice by the mayor)
the governor confirms who is elected

elect

MILITARY
the four presidial companies (San Diego, Santa Bárbara, Monterey, San Francisco) — underpaid, decaying
+ a citizen militia raised in emergencies
(the "Defensores de la Patria")
the Comandante General commands them

EX-MISSIONS (Franciscan)
SECULARIZED from 1834 — decree pub. Monterey (C-A 43 d254), Figueroa's reglamento Aug 1834 (C-A 43 d375); estates pass to lay administrators; Indian alcaldes still run daily affairs;
mayordomos oversee the ex-mission ranchos
(run by the friars/administradores — not the bishop)

Ciudadanos (citizens)
vecinos / Californios — the settler townsfolk,
who vote for the ayuntamientos

Soldiers & militiamen
the presidial troops + able-bodied vecinos
called up for defense

Ex-neophytes & laborers
Indians "freed" by secularization —
in practice mostly kept on as estate labor

▶ WHAT CHANGED FROM THE SPANISH SYSTEM

1) An ELECTED assembly (the Diputación) now shares power with and checks the governor. 2) The missions are SECULARIZED (1834) — the friars lose the estates. 3) California's status shifts TERRITORY (1824) → DEPARTMENT (1836), which adds prefects. 4) The capital moves Monterey → LOS ÁNGELES (1845).

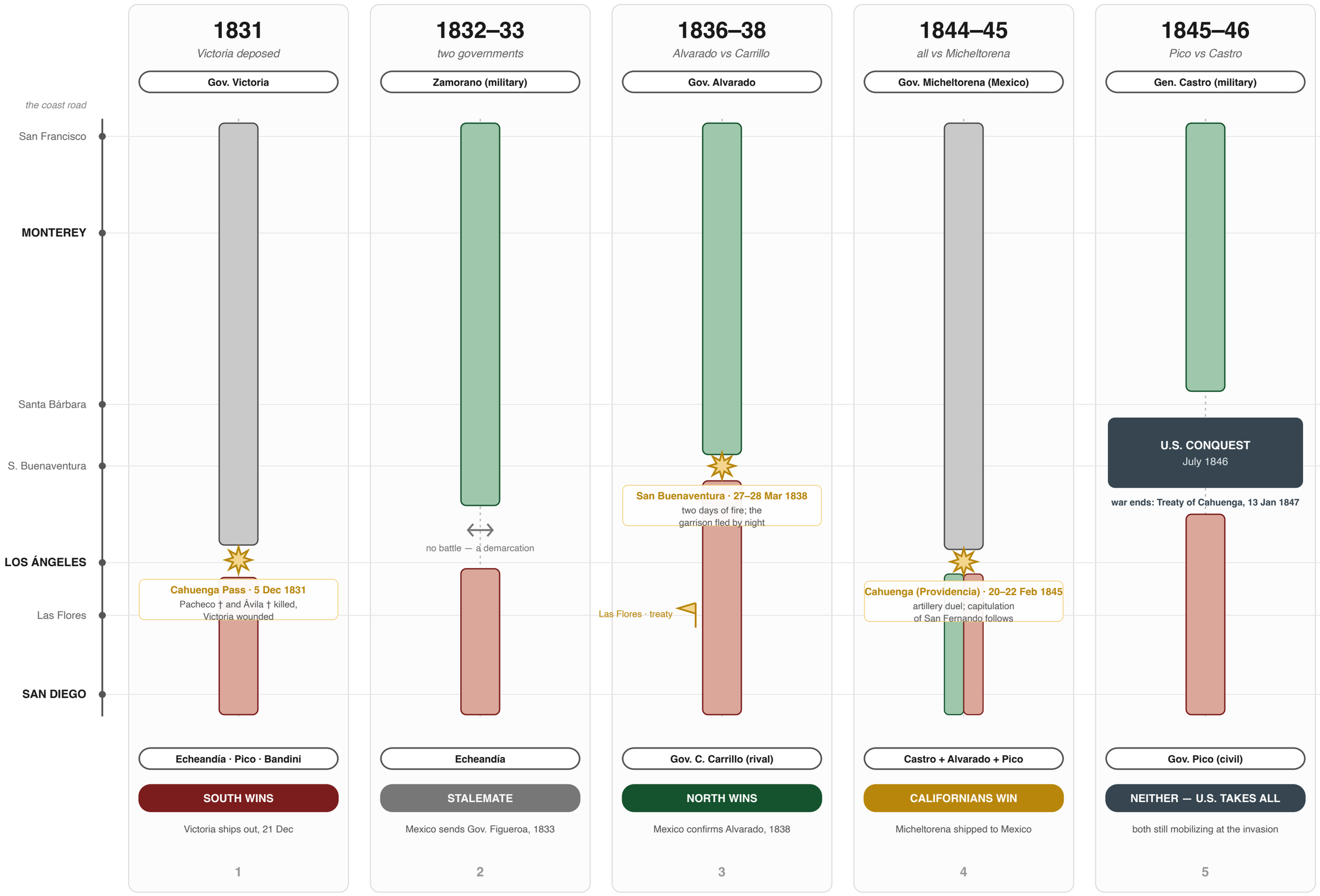
HOW TO READ THIS CHART

- solid arrow = chain of command (appoints / issues orders / answers to)
- double-headed arrow = shared / mutual power (the governor and the assembly)
- dotted arrow = a church line of authority (the state claiming the ex-missions)
- = the governor (Jefe Político + Comandante General)
- = the elected assembly (the key new institution vs. the Spanish period)
- = Church institutions (the ex-missions AND the bishop's diocese — kept separate)

The bishop is drawn as its own box, apart from the government chain. Bishop of Sonora /García Diego /Indian alcaldes & mayordomos sourced from the C-A catalog (ca25, ca34, ca37).
Source: Aodhan Coyne, research file "governor-of-california-office-profile" · Bancroft, History of California III · Diputación roster: C-A 59 d4. Compiled 2026-08-04 · updated 2026-10-16.
Baja California stayed a separate jefatura after 1822, but the military command was at times held over "ambas Californias" (C-A 18 d398, C-A 27 d113); Alta convicts served presidio terms at Loreto (C-A 18 d398).

NORTH vs SOUTH · THE CIVIL CONFLICTS OF MEXICAN CALIFORNIA

Territorio de la Alta California · Departamento de Californias · five breaks, 1831–1846 — each panel is a snapshot of who held the coast road



HOW TO READ · each panel colors the coast road by who held it, top (north) to bottom (south)

northern party · southern party · Mexico's sitting governor · battle · treaty / capitulation

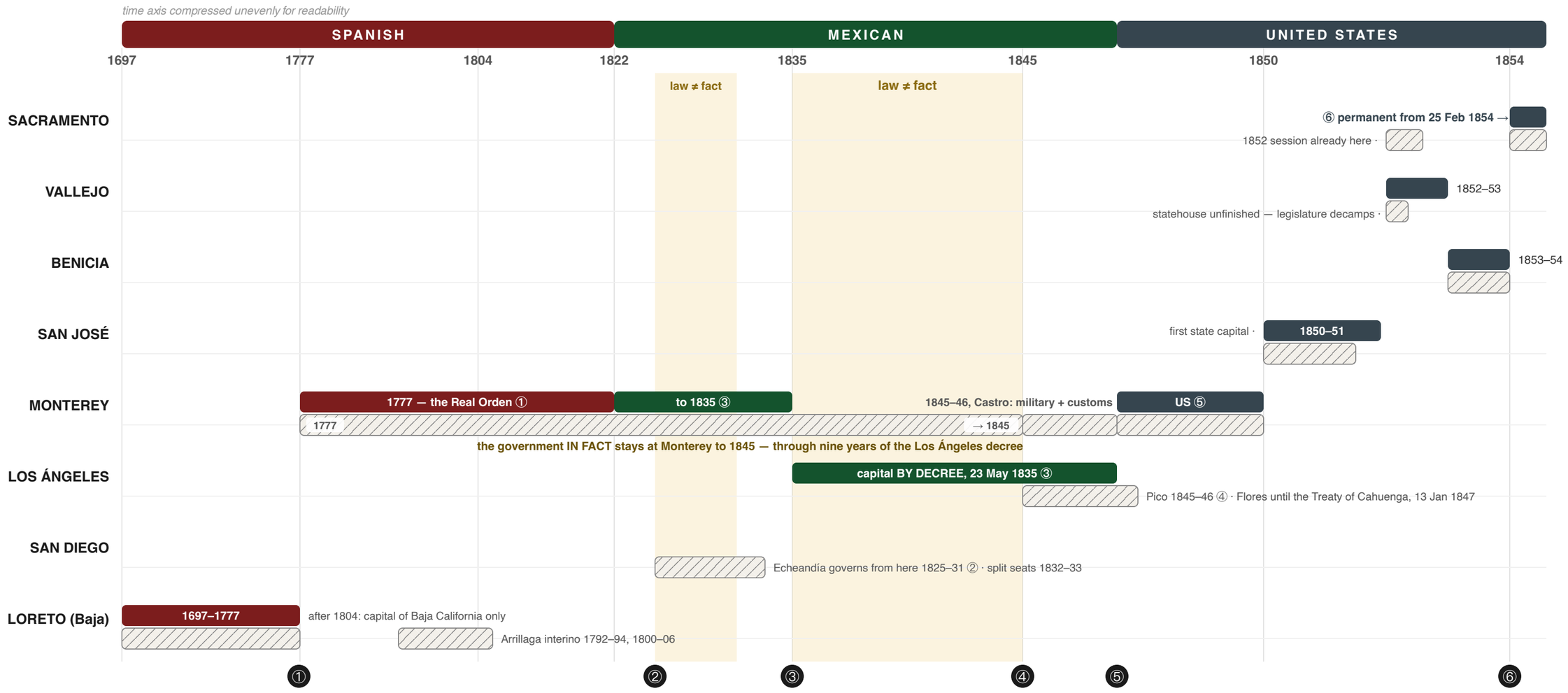
Documents (BANC MSS C-A, readable at archivesofcalifornia.com): ① C-A 28 d38 · C-A 42 d1337 · C-A 43 d876 ② C-A 19 d183, d218, d221 ③ C-A 29 d228, d252 · C-A 43 d811 ④ C-A 30 d216, d230, d232 ⑤ C-A 31 d3–d92

Battle details not preserved in C-A (the deaths at Cahuenga 1831; Las Flores; the 1845 artillery duel; the Jan 1847 Treaty of Cahuenga) are from Bancroft, History of California III–V.

Source: Aodhan Coyne, research file "governor-of-california-office-profile" · BANC MSS C-A records as cited · Bancroft, History of California III–V. Compiled 2026-10-16.

THE CAPITALS OF CALIFORNIA · 1697–1854

the capital IN LAW (solid bar) vs where the government ACTUALLY SAT (striped bar) — cities north to south · Las Californias → Alta California → the State



THE ORDERS BEHIND THE BARS

① Real Orden, 19 Apr 1776: the governor to reside at Monterey (C-A 1 d85) — effective Feb 1777. The 1804 division leaves Loreto the capital of Baja only (executed 1806, C-A 25 d570/d587).

② No order moved anything: Echeandía simply resided at San Diego — his orders to Monterey are datelined there (C-A 27 d129–132). The Diputación stayed installed at Monterey (founding acta, C-A 59 d4).

③ Decree of the Mexican Congress, 23 May 1835: Los Ángeles erected into a city and THE CAPITAL (C-A 43 d389; published in California 4 Jan 1836, C-A 44 d428) — not obeyed for nine years; under the 1836 regime the capital stayed formally "aún no señalada" (C-A 37 d468).

④ 1845: Pico and the Assembly finally sit at Los Ángeles ("the capital," C-A 31 d355) — but the military command and the customs stay at Monterey with Castro (C-A 31 d3–d92): the capital itself splits in two.

⑤ US conquest, July 1846: military governors at Monterey. The war in California ends with the Capitulation (Treaty) of Cahuenga, 13 Jan 1847 — Andrés Pico to Frémont (Bancroft V); the 1849 Constitutional Convention meets at Monterey. [standard record]

⑥ Statehood: San José 1850 (1849 Constitution) → Vallejo 1852 → Benicia 1853 → SACRAMENTO from 25 Feb 1854, permanent (1854 act; 1879 Constitution). [Statutes of California — beyond the C-A archive]

solid bar = capital IN LAW (red Spanish · green Mexican · slate US)

striped bar = where the government ACTUALLY sat

amber zone = law and fact disagree

Read any column top to bottom: when the solid bar and the striped bar are in different rows, California was governed from somewhere other than its legal capital.

Source: Aodhan Coyne, research file "governor-of-california-office-profile" · BANC MSS C-A records as cited (archivesofcalifornia.com) · Bancroft, History of California II–V · Statutes of California 1850–54. Compiled 2026-10-16.